

This Month in Statistics History: September

1937

On September 28, chief Soviet statistician Olimpiy Kvitkin is executed on the orders of Stalin. His census reports showed the catastrophic 1932 famine (Holodomor) caused death tolls in the millions and contradicted Stalin's claim that the population was increasing. Declared part of a "serpent's nest of traitors in the apparatus of Soviet statistics," other statisticians involved in the census are also arrested and shot.

https://magazine.amstat.org/blog/2025/09/02/tmh_sept/

- Andreas Georgiou, former president of the Hellenic Statistical Authority (ELSTAT), Greece
- Led ELSTAT from 2010 to 2015
- Under his leadership, ELSTAT revised Greece's deficit and debt statistics for 2009 to show that the country's fiscal situation was significantly worse than previously reported
- He was prosecuted on several charges, including violation of duty, complicity against the state, and slander

August 25, 2025

To whom it may concern,

We welcome the decision of the Supreme Civil and Criminal Court of Greece to reopen the case for alleged violation of duty against former Greek chief statistician, Andreas Georgiou, with proceedings scheduled for September 19, 2025. After 14 years of legal persecution against Georgiou, we believe the renewed consideration is an opportune moment for the Court to uphold the fundamental principles of statistical independence and professional integrity for Greece and the world.

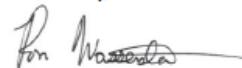
Dr. Georgiou was previously sentenced to two years in prison for failing to submit the corrected 2006-2009 deficit and debt statistics of Greece to a vote but acting in accordance with the principle of professional independence outlined in the European Statistics Code of Practice (Indicator 1.4). The reopening of this case follows the 2023 European Court of Human Rights ruling in favor of Dr. Georgiou, finding that Greece violated his right to a fair trial, and the Greek government's subsequent withdrawal of its challenge to this ruling.

This is the only case against Dr. Georgiou remaining open; the rest of altogether seven cases (including those involving his former colleagues at the national statistics office) have been dropped. The charges in this case should be dropped as well.

Criminal sanctions for developing and presenting independent, objective, and reliable statistical data are not justifiable in any circumstances. By dropping the charges, the Court would be showing that Greece embraces the international statistical principles enshrined in the UN Fundamental Principles of Official Statistics and the European Statistics Code of Practice. It would signal that Greece chooses accurate and impartial statistics, which are manifestly in the interests of Greece, the EU, and the world.

More is at stake here than the persecution of an individual official statistician. Official statistics themselves and all who produce them are on trial. The integrity of official statistics depends on the protection of those who produce them. As Executive Director of the American Statistical Association, a non-partisan scientific organization, I stand with Dr. Georgiou and urge Greek officials to end these unjust prosecutions for the good of all, exonerate him of the remaining conviction of alleged violation of duty, and issue a public apology.

Sincerely,



Ron Wasserstein, PhD
 Executive Director

Tanzania Drops Threat of Prison Over Publishing Independent Statistics

Amendment to Statistics Act a Step in Right Direction for Free Expression



Oryem Nyeko
Researcher, Africa Division
[@oryembley](#)



Part of the city of Dar es Salaam is seen from an airplane, in Tanzania, March 20, 2018. © 2018 AP Photo/Ben Curtis

Last week, Tanzania's Parliament [passed an amendment to its troubling Statistics Act](#), which removes a threat of prison for civil society groups that publish independent statistical information.

The Statistics Act of 2015 made it a crime for people in Tanzania to publish "false official statistics" or to disseminate information that would result in the "distortion of facts." In 2017, [police arrested opposition politician Zitto Kabwe](#) for violating the law for remarks he made about Tanzania's economic growth. He was never charged and eventually released. In 2018, Parliament amended the law to make it a crime to publish statistics without the approval of the National Bureau of Statistics, and disseminating statistics

MORE READING



July 2, 2019 | Report
Kenya: Nairobi Police Executing Suspects



July 2, 2019 | Commentary
Moving on From Ethiopia's Torturous Past

MOST VIEWED

MOST SHARED

1 August 7, 2019 | News Release

South Africa: Decriminalise Sex Work



2 October 1, 2019 | Dispatches

Marathoners Wilt in Qatar's Oppressive Heat



3 September 30, 2019 | Dispatches

Filming the Philippines' 'War on Drugs'



4 September 30, 2019 | News Release

Bangladesh: Halt Plans to Fence-In



<https://www.hrw.org/news/2019/07/03/tanzania-drops-threat-prison-over-publishing-independent-statistics>